

ORIGINAL ARTICLE

Civil Society and Democracy

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ABSTRACT

Objective: This study aims to provide a first-cut empirical analysis of whether civil society promotes democratic governance or only supports specific aspects of democracy.

Methods: This study fits a battery of OLS regression models against cross-national, time-series data for 173 countries from 1900 to 2016.

Results: Civil society is likely to strengthen democracy: it is conducive to some dimensions of democracy but not as closely as we expected. Specifically, civil society is likely to help fulfill democracy's promise of electoral, participatory, and institutional conditions but exert little to no effect on other democratic dimensions.

Conclusion: This study hopes that the empirical findings will stimulate further research on civil society and democracy to obtain a more complete sense of how these essential concepts are connected to each other and the success of political systems. At a time when both civil society and democracy seem embattled in a range of locations, the real-world relevance of this academic research becomes apparent as well.

1 | Civil Society at the Forefront

Among factors that may incentivize authoritarian regimes to transition to democracy or may improve the quality and depth of existing self-governing polities, the role of civil society comes to the forefront (Choi and James 2025; Grahn and Lührmann 2021; Han and Kim 2022). Scholarly inquiry along such lines goes back to the publication of Alexis de Tocqueville's (1835) *Democracy in America*. What should be expected in a society as the realm of independent civic organizations that lies between the state and market on the one hand, and the family unit on the other hand becomes more collectively active? Put simply, will civil society make political life more democratic? This seems likely if its members participate, collaborate, and develop into citizens capable of upholding democracy, or unlikely if its members are apolitical (Linz 2000). These possible linkages between civil society and democracy have frequently been mentioned in various prominent studies (e.g., Putnam 1993). Still, little empirical

evidence that is consistent and robust exists across time and space.

The main purpose of this study is to examine conflicting findings on the role of civil society with the help of empirical data rather than offering theoretical innovations. Accordingly, we provide two theoretical arguments based on work already in place. First, as a collective force, civil society cultivates the overall quality of democracy. Second, the beneficial effect of civil society varies depending on the type of democracy at issue. We put these theoretical expectations through new systematic testing with longitudinal data. Our empirical research brings contemporary available datasets and advanced statistical methods to bear in systematically examining the theoretical argument on how civil society advances democracy. The empirical analysis is slightly off from our theoretical arguments: (1) civil society strengthens democracy in general; and (2) civil society plays an important role in certain forms of democratic political systems but not in

the same way we expected. Civil society is likely to help fulfill democracy's promise of electoral, participatory, and institutional conditions, but exerts little to no effect on other democratic dimensions. By investigating potential mutual causality, we increase confidence that the causal direction goes from civil society to democracy. In addition, when evaluating the effects of democratic versus non-democratic civil society organizations, we uncover that while the former tend to increase democracy, the latter tend to decrease democracy.

2 | Civil Society and Democracy

In this study, we view civil society as consisting of a number of voluntary groups or organizations, such as labor unions and churches, collectively working in the interest of the members and often citizens as a whole, whether in the form of protest or not but operating outside of government. Ever since the concept of democracy was born, government responsiveness to demands from the public has been an essential feature (Dahl 1971; see also McLaverty 2002): the basis of electoral democracy, in which public interests are expressed through free and fair elections. However, democracy goes beyond the mere presence of free and fair elections (Collier and Levitsky 1997; Sommerfeldt 2013). Democracy exhibits multidimensional features as it “presumes fully contested elections with full suffrage and the absence of massive fraud, combined with effective guarantees of civil liberties, including freedom of speech, assembly, and association” (Collier and Levitsky 1997, 434).

How does civil society cultivate the quality of democratic governance? We contend that civil society enables powerless citizens to form a united front against authoritarianism, setting in motion the development of democratic political systems. When civil society becomes a united front, it can also solve collective action problems—encouraging members to join pro-democracy movements and fighting indifference, consequently leading to a more effective and successful protest against authoritarian leaders. Compared to individual citizens who face incentives against participating in pro-democracy movements—a greater public good for the nation—civil society as a collective force can organize and mobilize citizen demands for democracy. Since people are generally concerned with immediate material gains rather than public goods, automatic and widespread individual participation is not easily obtained along the road to democracy (Olson 1982). Civil society can step in and effectively deal with the collective action problem for individual citizens (Ostrom and Ahn 2009, 19). In this context, we project civil society as collective “resistance to a tyrannical regime” (Foley and Edwards 1996, 39) and similarly “resistance and checking power” (Fung 2003, 522). Furthermore, a state-of-the-art data analysis, based on 156 states from 1900 to 2014 ($N = 10,205$), produces the conclusion that “active citizen engagement has salutary effects for democracy” (Bernhard and Edgell 2022, 199, 200). Accordingly, a strong civil society serves as a formidable collective force on the road to democracy.

The above discussion culminates in the first hypothesis:

Hypothesis 1. *Increases in civil society are associated with increases in the overall quality of democracy.*

3 | Civil Society and Different Dimensions of Democracy

In this section, we build on existing work by detailing the possibility, even likelihood, that civil society strengthens democracy in some ways but not others. Although it appears to be a coherent system of governance in which high levels of political competition, unhindered public participation, and guaranteed civil liberties naturally exist in tandem, democracy may also be seen as an assemblage of diverse parts that actually exist in tension. More specifically, some features of civil society enhance popular inclusion in political life, while others constrain rulers once they assume public office (Grahn and Lührmann 2021). We argue that the collective action function of civil society is well embedded with regard to achieving some dimensions of democracy more than others. We review six different dimensions of democracy (electoral, participatory, institutional, liberal, deliberative, and egalitarian) and contend that the effect of civil society may vary depending on the breadth and depth of each dimension of democracy.

Electoral, participatory, and institutional democracy ensure that a wide range of citizens will enjoy the basics of political rights. These three aspects of democracy enable us to assess the breadth of democracy as experienced by individual, undifferentiated citizens. Deepening democracy as a concept, but short of conceptual stretching, as presciently identified by Sartori (1970) includes liberal, deliberative, and egalitarian aspects. These three elements of democracy enable us to evaluate the depth of democracy. While important to a more complete evolution of democracy, the liberal, deliberative, and egalitarian dimensions usually come into force after the electoral, participatory, and institutional ones. One way to help distinguish between the preceding two subsets is through the classic philosophical exposition from Rawls (1971). Rather than a purely individualistic sense of what constituted a good society, Rawls (1971) urged more of a collectivist frame of reference. In particular, we are encouraged to focus on the position of those least well off in any society that might form now or in the future.

The electoral, participatory, and institutional dimensions identify the breadth of democracy, and civil society is expected to exert influence there most directly. A prominent instance would be the achievement of voting rights. The liberal, deliberative, and egalitarian dimensions focus on democracy in depth and, all other things being equal, are less readily open to effects from civil society. It takes time for civil society to relish civil and political rights, especially under authoritarianism. The realization of equality in a society serves as another prominent example here.

Put differently, associations that are voluntary and connected with others can be expected to have salutary effects on the breadth of democracy due to the promotion of generalized trust (Paxton 2007, 62). Associations with mandatory membership, such as the military under draft conditions, are generally associated with the state. The trust that membership in a voluntary association promotes is very likely to spill over into the electoral, participatory, and institutional aspects of democracy by reducing the naturally harmful effects of social alienation. Furthermore, if associations are connected with each other, synergistic effects will follow on, promoting generalized trust and, in turn, the breadth of

democracy and attendant goal achievement (Sommerfeldt 2013, 282). In addition, civil society associations that are broad in nature have the best ‘track record’ in promoting the breadth of democracy. Biswas and Basak (2013, 254) emphasize the pursuit of “common interests”—and presumably the more inclusive, the better—for electoral, participatory, and institutional democracy.

How can specific types of civil society be expected to impact electoral, participatory, and institutional dimensions of democracy?

3.1 | Electoral Democracy

As civil society becomes more active and mobilized, we expect a heightened benefit for electoral democracy, in which citizens have the opportunity to provide their input into the political decision-making process by electing representatives through universal, free, equal, direct, and secret suffrage. Several examples suggest a relationship between civil society and electoral democracy. One of the most memorable voter registration drives culminated in the purple fingers and smiles of Iraqis who voted for the first time in many years in 2010. Despite the hardship and desperation of war and continued attacks from militants, Iraqi voters elected their representatives by dipping a finger in purple ink with pride (Brown and Hamzawy 2007). As South Korea’s civil society became more active and mobilized against authoritarian regimes, a more awakened citizenry and increased voter participation emerged. Civic organizations actively motivated more Koreans to vote in national elections (Oberdorfer 2001). To move away from authoritarianism, civil society organizations in Egypt, Georgia, Lebanon, Ukraine, and Kyrgyzstan encouraged more of their citizens to participate in electoral democracy (Yom 2005). Organized actors in civil society can produce accountability for a government through the ability to mobilize in favor of opponents during an election (Hegre et al. 2020). Simply put, vigorous civic activism is more likely to increase the quality of electoral democracy.¹

3.2 | Participatory Democracy

When citizens learn how to participate in civic organizations, they can also be expected to grasp how to advance ideas and interests (Leonard et al. 2020). This is a quality that citizens should acquire and be able to express, without fear, in high levels of participatory democracy (Bromo et al. 2024; Owen 2008). This underlines citizen participation in political decision-making, especially direct involvement rather than action mediated through elected representatives. Extensive theorizing and research from sociology support the assertions that civil society associations, which “create opportunities for face-to-face interactions,” are able to promote “participatory impulses and ideals” (Fung 2003, 531). In fact, civil societies have turned many members into active political participants as they “provide a training ground for new political leaders” (Paxton 2002, 254). Examples include Lech Wałęsa, a shipyard electrician by trade, who became the leader of Solidarity and led a successful pro-democratic effort that ended communist rule in Poland in 1989 (Steffoff 1992), and Moon Jae-in, an active member of a local association of lawyers who defended cases involving labor rights issues in South Korea (Moon 2017). Each went on to become president of his country.

3.3 | Institutional Democracy

Citizens who learn how to become involved actively in political processes and transform themselves into political leaders should also help to enhance institutional democracy, which places checks and balances either among the “three branches of government” or between citizens and the government (Russett 1993; Marshall et al. 2014). The emergence of such citizens is likely to help cultivate institutional democracy, since it leads to the imposition of formal, institutionalized constraints on the ability of the top executive to exercise excessive power. It is not difficult to imagine that civic organizations, especially those related to democracy movements, desire to implement political reforms that constrain the arbitrary authority of top leaders, such as presidents and prime ministers, and that strengthen the degree of checks and balances among branches of the government (Uhlir 2009; Grahn and Lüthmann 2021).² Thus, vigorous civic participation is more likely to increase the quality of institutional democracy.

The above discussion leads to the second hypothesis.

Hypothesis 2. *Increases in civil society are likely to promote increases in electoral, participatory, and institutional democracy.*

3.4 | Liberal Democracy

The liberal principle of democracy is anchored to civil liberties, political rights, and the rule of law. For example, it highlights the importance of protections for individual and minority rights against the tyranny of the state and the majority (Collier and Levitsky 1997; for a diverging view, see Lewis 2011). However, that may not be compatible with the interests of civic organizations, especially when they were created to serve their own interests at the possible expense of public goods. As noted earlier, some civic organizations may even be keen on channeling popular energies to punish hated minorities (Grahn and Lüthmann 2021). Examples include groups that try to advance racial supremacy in the U.S. and those that supported apartheid, a system of institutionalized racial segregation that existed in South Africa and South West Africa (now Namibia) for decades. Another way of conceptualizing the potentially unhealthy relationship between civil society and liberal democracy is to look at resistance from authoritarian leaders. It may be the case that expansion of the associational sector reflects autocratic rulers’ strategy of controlled liberalization rather than giving way to liberalized democracy. For example, though challenged by various civic organizations, many rulers in the Middle East “remain robust in their will and capacity to repress” individual citizens (Yom 2005, 14).

3.5 | Deliberative Democracy

Deliberative democracy, which adopts elements from majority rule may also not come to light despite the emergence of a strong civil society. Some civic organizations may want to have their voice heard or vigorously press their cause forward. As noted in previous and influential studies (e.g., Olson 1982; Lowi 1979), some special interest groups promote positions that often are detrimental to the economy and democracy. These civic

organizations articulate interests through strategic action and are not cooperative participants in a deliberative dialogue. Thus, these entities may prefer attacking the virtue of a deliberative democratic process over reaching an agreement among all member organizations (Öberg and Svensson 2012).

3.6 | Egalitarian Democracy

While civil society activities are expanding, a country still may have difficulty becoming an egalitarian democracy that is designed to promote equality for all people. Various civic organizations may not wish to see the rights and freedoms of nonmembers protected equally across civic groups or to have all collectivities and individuals enjoy equal access to power. This is because each civic organization has its own mandate and interests to pursue and can become less of a contributor to egalitarian democracy. For example, although racial equality is desirable in an egalitarian society, some demographically based organizations oppose that public good. Although religious freedom should be achieved under egalitarian democracy, religious persecution and discrimination are not uncommon around the world, with anti-semitism as perhaps the most longstanding example (Walzer 2002; van Rahden 2008; Sigman and Lindberg 2019; Basedau, Fox, and Zellman 2023).

Further discussion of civil society thus leads to the third hypothesis:

Hypothesis 3. *Increases in civil society are unlikely to cultivate significant increases in liberal, deliberative, and egalitarian democracy.*

4 | Research Design

4.1 | Model Building

To empirically test the three hypotheses above, we collected a large dataset of 173 countries during the period from 1900 to 2016. Data availability determines the sample size and study period. We build a baseline statistical model to determine the overall and individual qualities of democracy as follows:

$$\text{Democracy}_{it} = \alpha_1 + \alpha_2 \text{Civil Society}_{it-1} + \alpha_3 \text{Democracy}_{it-1} \\ + \text{Country Dummies}_i + \text{Year Dummies}_t + \varepsilon_{it}.$$

The model assumes that democracy at time t is a function of civil society at time $t-1$, democracy at time $t-1$,³ a complete set of country dummies, and a full set of year dummies, making the unit of analysis the country-year.

4.2 | Estimation Methods

Given that the dependent variable, democracy, is continuous (explained below), the estimation method is OLS regression with cluster-robust standard errors. Since no estimation method is perfect, we perform a series of robustness tests with different model specifications. When an OLS regression is run against

pooled panel data without accounting for fixed-effects that can control for omitted variables (which differ between countries but are constant over time), the estimates it produces may be biased. Green et al. (2001, 442) demonstrate that “analyses of pooled cross-section data that make no allowance for fixed unobserved differences between [countries] often produce biased results.” A complete set of year dummies is also incorporated to account for unobserved factors that change over time within countries and may be correlated in such a way that the actual effect of civil society is underestimated.

4.3 | Dependent Variable: Democracy

We operationalize democracy by calculating the average of the six different dimensions of governance: electoral, liberal, participatory, deliberative, egalitarian, and institutional. To obtain data for electoral, liberal, participatory, deliberative, and egalitarian democracy, we consult the varieties of democracy (V-Dem) Project, which is the recipient of the 2016 Lijphart/Przeworski/Verba dataset award (Coppedge et al. 2020).

Electoral democracy measures how well rulers respond to citizens. It is achieved through competitive elections where suffrage is widespread. In this system, elections are conducted fairly, free from fraud or systematic irregularities, and the outcomes influence the selection of the country’s chief executive.

Liberal democracy refers to the extent of civil liberties and the independence of institutions. It emphasizes equality before the law and individual freedoms, including judicial and legislative constraints on the executive branch. This framework protects individual and minority rights against the potential tyranny of the state and the majority.

Participatory democracy evaluates the degree of active citizen involvement in all electoral and non-electoral political processes. It operates on the belief that direct participation by citizens is the most desirable form of governance whenever feasible.

Deliberative democracy highlights the importance of public debate, open-minded discussions, and the role of consultative institutions. A deliberative process is characterized by public reasoning aimed at the common good, contrasting with decisions driven by emotional appeals, narrow interests, or coercion.

Egalitarian democracy assesses whether the rights and freedoms of individuals are equally protected across all social groups, resources are distributed equally, and all groups and individuals have equal access to power.

Institutional democracy is defined by the distribution of powers among different parts of government, which affect and control each other to prevent any single part from becoming too powerful. Russett (1993) provides evidence that having a high quality of institutional checks and balances makes it more difficult for democratic states to use force against one another.

The V-Dem data were derived from an expert survey of more than 3000 experts from different countries worldwide. Each democracy is coded as a composite index of numerous features of its

TABLE 1 | Civil society and democracy, 1900–2016: baseline models.

Variables	Five Year Data: Fixed Effect					
	Electoral Democracy	Liberal Democracy	Participatory Democracy	Deliberative Democracy	Egalitarian Democracy	Institutional Democracy
	1	2	3	4	5	6
Civil Society _{it-1}	0.009** (0.003)	0.003 (0.002)	0.005** (0.002)	0.005 (0.002)	0.003 (0.002)	0.020*** (0.006)
Electoral Democracy _{it-1}	0.751*** (0.021)					
Liberal Democracy _{it-1}		0.816*** (0.018)				
Participatory Democracy _{it-1}			0.794*** (0.017)			
Deliberative Democracy _{it-1}				0.795*** (0.018)		
Egalitarian Democracy _{it-1}					0.832*** (0.015)	
Institutional Democracy _{it-1}						0.674*** (0.027)
Intercept	0.014 (0.008)	0.020** (0.007)	0.004 (0.005)	0.003 (0.007)	0.009 (0.005)	0.076*** (0.021)
R ²	0.91	0.92	0.93	0.91	0.94	0.84
Countries	173	173	173	173	173	165
N	3,283	3,283	3,283	3,283	3,283	2,181

Notes: Robust standard errors are in parentheses.

* $p < 0.05$ ** $p < 0.01$ *** $p < 0.001$, two-tailed tests

own dimensions, calculated by taking the point estimates from a Bayesian factor analysis model of various democracy-related indicators. It is an interval measure, ranging from 0 (most undemocratic) to 1 (most democratic) in theory. Since we focus on whether civil society promotes democracy, not democratic transition, the interval measure is optimal for our analysis. It also should be noted that since six democracy indicators are the dependent variables, they do not appear in the same model but in separate models. Accordingly, we have little concern about empirical overlap among these democracy indicators. Data for institutional democracy are taken from Polity, the most common dataset used in the conflict literature (Marshall et al. 2014).⁴ To make institutional democracy consistent with the other democracy indicators, we standardize the dataset's polity2 variable on a scale of 0 to 1.

4.4 | Main Independent Variable: Civil Society

We deem civil society a mobilizing force for collective action against the authoritarian regime. Since civil society's mobilization depends on how actively it can involve powerless individuals in civic organizations, we measure civil society in the context that people are more or less actively engaged in civil society

organizations.⁵ The data are garnered from the V-Dem Project (Bernhard et al. 2017). The project's variable name is CSO participatory environment, ranging from -3.36 (least active) to 3.16 (most active) for annual data. Since our hypotheses are about the continuous, not threshold, effects of civil society, the interval measure is optimal for our analysis. Although our hypotheses stipulate a positive relationship between civil society and democracy, our results could show a negative relationship if civil society were actually detrimental, i.e., co-opted by the authoritarian regime. This is a matter of empirical verification; however, as shown in the next section, our robustness analysis finds a positive, not negative, relationship, confirming our original conjecture.

Based on our democracy and civil society data collection, we construct annual, five-year, and ten-year panels. Since many studies use yearly data, we provide annual statistical analysis for comparison purposes. Since the variables change slowly over time, grouping years together into periods allows us to obtain more accurate within-estimates of the variables. This is a standard practice in research designs that must cope with low-variation data (for more details on how and why to group years together, see Acemoglu et al. 2008; Boix 2011; Treisman 2015). We calculate the moving average for five-and ten-year panels.

TABLE 2 | Civil society and democracy, 1900–2016: full models.

Variables	Five Year Data: Fixed Effect					
	Electoral Democracy	Liberal Democracy	Participatory Democracy	Deliberative Democracy	Egalitarian Democracy	Institutional Democracy
	1	2	3	4	5	6
Civil Society _{it-1}	0.013* (0.006)	0.006 (0.005)	0.008* (0.004)	0.009 (0.006)	0.004 (0.003)	0.025** (0.009)
GDP Per Capita _{it-1}	−0.001 (0.011)	0.007 (0.010)	0.004 (0.008)	0.009 (0.011)	0.005 (0.008)	−0.017 (0.019)
Inflation _{it-1}	0.000** (0.000)	0.000* (0.000)	0.000** (0.000)	0.000*** (0.000)	0.000* (0.000)	0.000* (0.000)
Education _{it-1}	−0.004 (0.006)	−0.002 (0.005)	−0.002 (0.004)	−0.002 (0.005)	−0.002 (0.004)	−0.005 (0.007)
Party Institutionaliztn _{it-1}	0.113** (0.036)	0.081** (0.030)	0.072** (0.024)	0.101** (0.034)	0.070** (0.024)	0.066 (0.047)
Oil Reserves _{it-1}	23.685 (12.254)	−1.363 (11.751)	−1.665 (8.306)	8.652 (13.036)	2.553 (8.625)	−12.411 (18.39)
Muslim Population _{it-1}	0.000 (0.001)	0.000 (0.001)	0.000 (0.001)	0.001 (0.001)	0.000 (0.001)	−0.002 (0.002)
Electoral Democracy _{it-1}	0.643*** (0.038)					
Liberal Democracy _{it-1}		0.708*** (0.036)				
Participatory Democracy _{it-1}			0.677*** (0.033)			
Deliberative Democracy _{it-1}				0.662*** (0.037)		
Egalitarian Democracy _{it-1}					0.721*** (0.028)	
Institutional Democracy _{it-1}						0.637*** (0.034)
Intercept	−0.014 (0.087)	−0.053 (0.073)	−0.056 (0.060)	−0.123 (0.081)	−0.062 (0.059)	0.209 (0.145)
R ²	0.86	0.91	0.89	0.87	0.92	0.83
Countries	142	142	142	142	142	140
N	1,450	1,450	1,450	1,450	1,450	1,426

Notes: Robust standard errors are in parentheses.

* $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$, two-tailed tests.

4.5 | Confounding Variables

We expand the baseline model by adding six confounding factors that could affect the dependent and independent variables, causing a spurious association: GDP per capita, inflation, education, party institutionalization, oil reserves, and the percentage of the muslim population. Due to space limitations, we relegate a detailed explanation of these variables to the supplementary material (for details, see Appendix 1, confounding variables).

Appendix 2 displays descriptive statistics for the five-year interval data.

5 | Empirical Results

To test Hypothesis 1, we regress the overall quality of democracy on civil society with the five-year panel data. The results indicate that the coefficient on civil society is 0.008, the standard error is

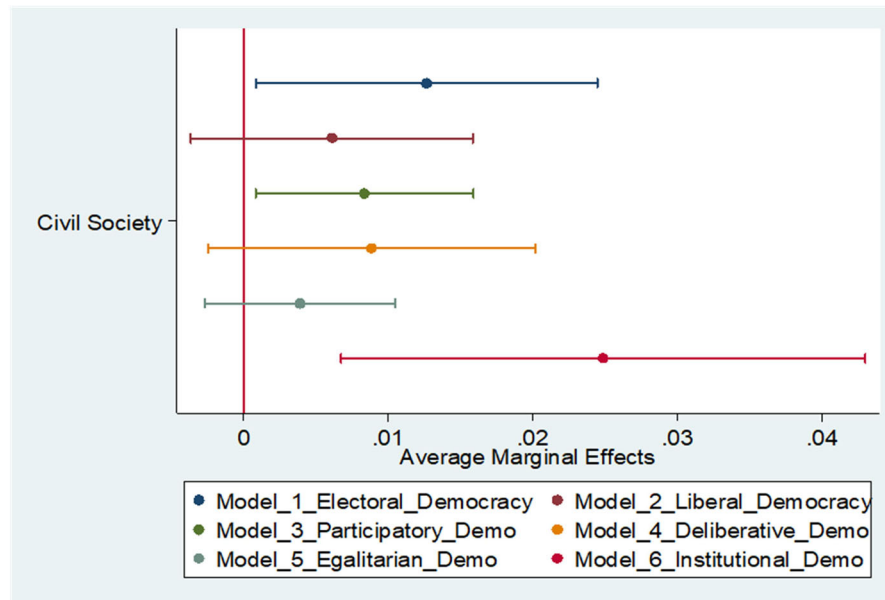


FIGURE 1 | Average marginal effects.

0.003, and the p -value is 0.010. Those numbers are not shown in tabular format to economize on space. This result supports Hypothesis 1: civil society is positively associated with increased democratic governance.

We move on to testing the second and third hypotheses. Table 1 presents the estimated results of each of the six dimensions of democracy. Civil society turns out to be significantly different from zero and its sign is positive when the outcome variable is electoral (Model 1), participatory (Model 3), and institutional (Model 6) democracy. This suggests that increased activities of civic organizations exert a significant and positive effect on political development, thereby increasing the degree of democratic governance in those polities. Despite such connections, civil society appears to have no bearing on liberal (Model 2), deliberative (Model 4), or egalitarian (Model 5) democracy. A previous history of democracy emerges as a highly significant and positive driver of current levels of democracy across models. This implies a considerable degree of path dependence in democratic practices.⁶

Table 2 examines whether the results in Table 1 hold when confounding factors are included in the model specification. The predicted relationship between civil society and

Democracy does not change drastically: while civil society is positively associated with electoral, participatory, and institutional democracy, it shows no significant connection with liberal, deliberative, and egalitarian democracy. Among the confounding factors, inflation and party institutionalization seem to be strong predictors of democracy, while the others, including GDP per capita, are generally not significant.

Since statistical significance does not necessarily suggest a meaningful finding, we report civil society's marginal/substantive effects for empirical verification. We plot average marginal effects in Figure 1 based on Table 2. Average marginal effects represent

the average change in probability when each independent variable increases by one unit. Figure 1 displays the analysis of the marginal effects. The beneficial impact of civil society is strong in Models 1 (electoral democracy), 3 (participatory democracy), and 6 (institutional democracy). The graphical presentation shows that the average marginal effects are consistent with significance tests. This gives further credence to the robustness of the main findings: civil society matters, depending on the type of democracy.

6 | Conclusion

When previous studies ponder whether civil society enforces and reinforces democratic polities, they try to find evidence in a single historical example or in a few countries during a limited period of time. Despite the many positive aspects of these qualitative studies, they are open to criticism for a lack of generalizability across time and space. More importantly, prior studies show conflicting findings: civil society is positively or negatively associated with democracy, depending on the sample and study period. This study is the first attempt to move forward the debate on the civil society and democracy nexus by using a sample of over 170 countries over a century. Our empirical investigation is fruitful in identifying a general pattern for how civil society affects the quality of democracy: connections are (1) positive and (2) sensitive to polity type, promoting some aspects of democracy more than others.

Taken together, results from quantitative analysis offer stronger support for the second and third civil society hypotheses than the first. Electoral, participatory, and institutional democracy are, if any, the dimensions most closely and positively associated with civil society. Liberal democracy is, however, hardly cultivated by civil society. This is not surprising, given that many civic organizations are primarily interested in promoting their interests rather than improving the rights of minority groups, a key

component of liberal democracy. Another notable finding is that, although one may suspect that democracy strengthens civil society rather than the other way around, our analysis finds no supporting empirical evidence.⁷

What specific types of civil society engagement should policymakers focus on to strengthen particular aspects of democracy? Two recommendations, based on the results of this study and others that focus on the mechanisms through which civil society impacts upon democracy, can be offered.

First, entities that emphasize youth, identified on a cross-national basis as not politically aware, for the most part, can play a role in enhancing civic engagement (Kuzma 2010, 249). “Civic learning,” as identified by Kuzma (2010: 252–253), includes (i) knowledge of electoral institutions and their processes; (ii) critical thinking and communication skills; and (iii) dispositions that promote participation. The electoral, participatory, and institutional dimensions of democracy are noted explicitly as benefiting from enhanced civic engagement of youth.

Second, given the importance already noted for connectedness, policymakers should focus on the promotion of civil society organizations that tend to be more isolated. Research reveals that trade unions, sports associations, and religious associations are less connected than other entities within civil society (Paxton 2002, 270). Greater integration of civil society associations with each other, according to Paxton (2002, 272), will promote generalized trust and impact upon the breadth of democracy.

Endnotes

¹ However, when civil society is divided along ethnic, religious, or economic cleavages, it is more favorable to political extremism and may become a threat to electoral democracy (Ekiert 2021).

² Although not common, some leaders who have emerged from civil society coalitions may attempt to close down political spaces once in power. Leaders in Zambia and Kyrgyzstan are examples (Pinckney 2018).

³ Given that past democratic practice is projected to influence current democratic practice, a lagged term for democracy is included as a control variable to allow for the dynamics of democracy in the model.

⁴ See <http://www.systemicpeace.org/inscrdata.html>.

⁵ What about more precise boundaries for civil society? This is understood as a potentially challenging question to answer. Mudasiru (2017: 68) asserts that “civil society organizations operate within a state and do not stand as a separate entity to the state.” Francois (2017: 18) adds that some define civil society organizations in terms of their functions, while others focus on individuals who are members of them. Nuances of measurement, in relation to metrics for democracy, are taken up at a later point.

⁶ Online appendices provide a series of robustness tests.

⁷ When we run an additional analysis with only democracies and non-democracies included in the sample, we find that the overall effects of civil society hold for both sub-samples. The results are not reported to save space and to avoid selecting on the dependent variable.

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OLS models include all control variables. **Appendix 9** Civil Society and Democracy, 1900–2016: Annual Data Yearly data is used instead of five-year data. **Appendix 10** Civil Society and Democracy, 1900–2016: Ten-Year Data Ten-year data is used instead of five-year data. **Appendix 11** Panel Vector Autoregression-Granger Causality Wald Test Showing estimated results for reverse causality. **Appendix 12** Exploring Further: Key Takeaways, Future Directions, and Policy Insights

Supporting Information

Additional supporting information can be found online in the Supporting Information section.

Appendix 1 Confounding Variables **Appendix 2** Descriptive Statistics for the Five Year Interval Data **Appendix 3** Civil Society and Democracy, 1900–2016: OLS Regression Models Displaying OLS results without considering fixed effects. **Appendix 4** Democratic versus Non-democratic Civil Society Organizations, 1900–2016: Baseline Models Showing OLS results when the civil society variable is recategorized into democratic and non-democratic civil society groups. **Appendix 5** Civil Society and Democracy, 1900–2016: Nonlinear Relationship Testing whether the relationship between civil society and democracy is non-linear. **Appendix 6** Civil Society and Democracy, 1900–2016: Civil Society Participation Index Reporting robustness estimates using an alternative indicator of civil society. **Appendix 7** Civil Society and Democracy, 1900–2016: Subcomponents of Each Democracy Displaying results after each composite democracy index is disaggregated into the most salient component. **Appendix 8** Civil Society and Democracy, 1900–2016: Subcomponents of Each Democracy Same as Appendix 7, but the